

Krubera Caves

Location The Arabika Massif of the western Caucasus Mountains, Georgia

There are several major cave systems in the thick beds of folded limestone of the Arabika Massif, including Krubera—the world's deepest known cave. It descends through a series of vertical pits and steep meandering passageways to a level 7,208 ft (2,197 m) below its entrance in a glacial valley. For

most of this depth, it is relatively dry, with no indication of major flooding, but the very deepest part, which was explored in 2012, is submerged.

Jeita Grotto

Location Nahr al-Kalb valley, Lebanon

This is the longest cave system in the Middle East, stretching for 6 miles (9 km). It has two separate,

but interconnected, sections, one 200 ft (60 m) below the other. The upper galleries contain the White Chamber and the Red Chamber. The former houses the world's longest stalactite, measuring 25 ft (8 m), while the limestone walls of the latter have been stained red by iron oxide. An underwater river flows through the lower galleries, and there is a subterranean lake. The chamber known as Grand Chaos Hall, is 1,640 ft (500 m) long.

Sambhar Salt Lake

Location Rajasthan, northwest India

This is India's largest saline lake, with a surface area of 75–90 square miles (190–230 square km) and a depth varying from 10 ft (3 m) after the monsoon to 2 ft (0.6 m) at the end of the dry season. It is set in an endorheic basin and receives water mainly from the Mendha and Rupangarh Rivers. When salinity levels reach a sufficient concentration, water is released through a dam into evaporation pools for commercial salt production. Many flamingos spend the winter at the lake.

Lonar Lake

Location Maharashtra, western India

India's largest impact-crater lake is almost circular in shape, with an average diameter of $\frac{3}{4}$ mile (1.2 km) and a depth of about 20 ft (6 m). The lake's waters are saline and are fed by one stream. The lake is surrounded by a crater rim, created when a meteorite impacted the Deccan Traps plateau. The date of impact is debated—estimates range from 570,000 to 52,000 years ago.

Borra Caves

Location The Eastern Ghats of Andhra Pradesh, eastern India

These are some of the deepest caves in India, containing formations such as stalactites, stalagmites, columns, and shapes reminiscent of mushrooms, a human brain, and a mother and child. The main chamber is 660 ft (200 m) long and 39 ft (12 m) high. Sulfurous springs discharge into the cave system, which is the source of the Gosthani River.



◀ THE LOWER CAVERN OF JEITA GROTTO